



Pillars of success: Sift Kaur Samra with her parents, Ramneek Kaur and Pawandeep Singh Samra. RITU RAJ KONWAR

ideas about practice and techniques. So to keep her relaxed, the two of us will usually watch films together in our hotel room. Over the last five days, we have watched Yodha, Heeramandi, and Laapataa Ladies on Netflix. Basically, my job is to ensure that she doesn't carry her shooting back to her hotel room," says Kaur.

Sumedha tries to do more. "Some time back, I got some ayurvedic oil that I rubbed onto Manu's fingers and knees. There's so much stress on her joints when she shoots. I have found that it has really helped her," she says.

While Sumedha is always looking for ways to give her daughter an extra edge, it wasn't always this way. For most of her daughter's career, Sumedha wouldn't travel with her for

competition. As the principal of a private school in the village of Gorla, Haryana, where Manu was born and raised, she felt her biggest responsibility was to the hundreds of children she was teaching. "Manu would often ask me to travel with her. But for a long time, I didn't feel it would be right. How could I focus on my one daughter at the cost of the thousand girls I was the principal for?" she says.

She started accompanying her daughter once in a while a few years ago before now travelling full time with her for domestic competitions at least. "After Manu moved her training base from Gorla to Faridabad, it became harder for me to commute back and forth to the school. Eventually I had to give it up," she says.

Sumedha says the stress of watching her daughter's preparation and matches is not too different from awaiting the exam results of

her students. "Manu competed at her first (2018) Commonwealth Games at the same time as we had our class 12 board exams. The nervousness I felt for both was the same," she says.

Although she's constantly by her daughter's side, Sumedha says she often wonders about returning to teaching. "Maybe after Manu's career, I'll go back to teaching," she says. For now, though, she's planning to travel along with her daughter to the Paris Games. "I don't yet know when I will go, but I would like to be with Manu when she competes," she says.

She's not the only parent, though, who is thinking of travelling to Paris. Sujit is planning to fly out for the Olympics, assuming Tilottama makes it to the Indian team. "I want to watch, but I don't want her to think I'm there. I will be booking a separate flight, so she doesn't even know I'm there," he says.